

MARRIAGE

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What are the roles in a biblical marriage? The man leads, and the woman follows. Right? But what does that look like? And what does the Bible actually show that as? Well, let's figure this out.

WHAT IS MARRIAGE

And the LORD God said, **It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him an help meet for him.**

Genesis 2:18

And the rib, which the LORD God had taken from man, made he a woman, and brought her unto the man. And Adam said, This is now bone of my bones, and flesh of my flesh: she shall be called Woman, because she was taken out of Man. **Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh.**

Genesis 2:22-24

And he answered and said unto them, Have ye not read, that he which made them at the beginning **made them male and female**, And said, **For this cause shall a man leave father and mother, and shall cleave to his wife: and they twain shall be one flesh? Wherefore they are no more twain, but one flesh. What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder.**

Matthew 19:4-6

But from the beginning of the creation **God made them male and female. For this cause shall a man leave his father and mother, and cleave to his wife; And they twain shall be one flesh: so then they are no more twain, but one flesh. What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder.**

Mark 10:6-9

Yet ye say, Wherefore? Because the LORD hath been witness between thee and the wife of thy youth, against whom thou hast dealt treacherously: **yet is she thy companion, and the wife of thy covenant.**

Malachi 2:14

For the woman which hath an husband is bound by the law to her husband so long as he liveth; but if the husband be dead, she is loosed from the law of her husband.

Romans 7:2

Marriage is honourable in all, and the bed undefiled: but whoremongers and adulterers God will judge.

Hebrews 13:4

What? know ye not that he which is joined to an harlot is one body? for two, saith he, shall be one flesh.

1 Corinthians 6:16

Nevertheless, to avoid fornication, let every man have his own wife, and let every woman have her own husband.

1 Corinthians 7:2

For this cause shall a man leave his father and mother, and shall be joined unto his wife, and they two shall be one flesh. This is a great mystery: but I speak concerning Christ and the church.

Ephesians 5:31-32

Marriage is a God-ordained covenant in which one man and one woman are joined by God, become one flesh, are witnessed by God, and are bound for life. Marriage is not a contract from the state. It is not a temporary thing.

From the Bible we see the following if we try and sum up what marriage is:

- Marriage originates with God, not man
 - God Himself declared that it was not good for man to be alone.
 - Marriage is God's solution to human incompleteness, not a social invention.
- Woman is created specifically for man as a corresponding helper
 - She is made from man and brought to man by God.
 - The relationship is intentional, relational, and complementary.
- Marriage forms a new primary human bond
 - A man leaves his father and mother.
 - The marital bond supersedes prior family allegiance.
- Marriage requires cleaving
 - The husband is to cling, hold fast, and be joined permanently to his wife.
 - This implies exclusivity, loyalty, and permanence.
- Marriage creates a "one flesh" union
 - One flesh is not symbolic only; it includes physical, relational, and covenantal unity.
 - Sexual union is presented as the act that expresses and seals this unity.
- Marriage is monogamous
 - One man to one woman ("his wife," "her husband").
 - The language is singular and exclusive throughout.
- Marriage is joined by God Himself
 - God is the active agent who joins husband and wife.
 - Because God joins the union, humans are warned not to separate it.
- Marriage is a covenant witnessed by God
 - God is explicitly named as the witness to marriage.
 - Marriage is not merely between two people but between the couple and God.
- Marriage is intended to be lifelong
 - The bond remains as long as both spouses live.
 - Death, not dissatisfaction, is what dissolves the bond.
- Marriage is honorable and morally protected
 - The marriage bed is declared undefiled.
 - Sexual activity outside this bond is judged.
- Sexual union creates real unity
 - Joining sexually makes two people "one body," even outside marriage.
 - This underscores why sex belongs within marriage.
- Marriage provides a God-ordained outlet for sexuality
 - Each man is to have his own wife, and each woman her own husband.
 - Marriage is presented as protection against fornication.
- Marriage reflects a greater spiritual reality
 - The one-flesh union points beyond itself.
 - It mirrors Christ's relationship with the church.

A good marriage, biblically, is a God-joined covenant in which a man and a woman leave prior allegiances to their families and form a new, primary bond with one another. It is marked by cleaving; a deliberate, ongoing commitment to remain united in purpose, loyalty, and life.

The husband and wife become one flesh, sharing not only physical intimacy but a shared identity, direction, and responsibility before God. Because God Himself is the witness and joiner of the union, the marriage is treated as sacred, permanent, and honorable, not casual or disposable.

Within that covenant, a good marriage is lived out through love, honor, faithfulness, and mutual care. The husband loves sacrificially, leads responsibly, and provides protection and stability; the wife responds with trust, respect, and partnership as a corresponding helper.

Sexual intimacy is kept pure and exclusive, strengthening the one-flesh bond rather than fracturing it. Together, the couple orders their life in a way that reflects something greater than themselves (the unity, faithfulness, and devotion seen in Christ and the church). In this way, a good marriage is not merely functional or happy, but ordered, enduring, and reflective of God's design.

THE BIBLE

This is most of what the Bible has to say toward just men when dealing with marriage. There's more that is directed toward just the wives, and more aimed at both spouses together. For a comprehensive view of what marriage in a biblical sense should look like, you need to read all three. A general knowledge of the Bible is also extremely wise for a marriage.

THE HUSBAND'S ROLE

Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh.

Genesis 2:24

But I would have you know, that **the head of every man is Christ; and the head of the woman is the man; and the head of Christ is God.**

1 Corinthians 11:3

Let **the husband render unto the wife due benevolence:** and likewise also the wife unto the husband.

1 Corinthians 7:3

For **the husband is the head of the wife, even as Christ is the head of the church: and he is the saviour of the body.**

Ephesians 5:23

Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it;

Ephesians 5:25

So ought men to love their wives as their own bodies. He that loveth his wife loveth himself.

Ephesians 5:28

Husbands, love your wives, and be not bitter against them.

Colossians 3:19

Likewise, ye husbands, dwell with them according to knowledge, giving honour unto the wife, as unto the weaker vessel, and as being heirs together of the grace of life; that your prayers be not hindered.

1 Peter 3:7

But if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath denied the faith, and is worse than an infidel.

1 Timothy 5:8

Marriage is honourable in all, and the bed undefiled: but whoremongers and adulterers God will judge.

Hebrews 13:4

THE WIFE'S ROLE

Therefore **as the church is subject unto Christ, so let the wives be to their own husbands in every thing.**

Ephesians 5:24

Wives, submit yourselves unto your own husbands, as unto the Lord.

Ephesians 5:22

Nevertheless let every one of you in particular so love his wife even as himself; and **the wife see that she reverence her husband.**

Ephesians 5:33

Wives, submit yourselves unto your own husbands, as it is fit in the Lord.

Colossians 3:18

Likewise, **ye wives, be in subjection to your own husbands;** that, if any obey not the word, they also may without the word be won by the conversation of the wives;

1 Peter 3:1

[Likewise, ye wives. . .] **Whose adorning let it not be that outward adorning of plaiting the hair, and of wearing of gold, or of putting on of apparel; But let it be the hidden man of the heart, in that which is not corruptible, even the ornament of a meek and quiet spirit, which is in the sight of God of great price. For after this manner in the old time the holy women also, who trusted in God, adorned themselves, being in subjection unto their own husbands: Even as Sara obeyed Abraham, calling him lord: whose daughters ye are, as long as ye do well, and are not afraid with any amazement.**

1 Peter 3:3-6

That they may **teach the young women to be sober, to love their husbands, to love their children, To be discreet, chaste, keepers at home, good, obedient to their own husbands,** that the word of God be not blasphemed.

Titus 2:4-5

Let the husband render unto the wife due benevolence: **and likewise also the wife unto the husband.**

1 Corinthians 7:3

Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: **and they shall be one flesh.**

Genesis 2:24

Marriage is honourable in all, and the bed undefiled: but whoremongers and adulterers God will judge.

Hebrews 13:4

BIBLE FOR BOTH

Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh. And they were both naked, the man and his wife, and were not ashamed.

Genesis 2:24-25

Let the husband render unto the wife due benevolence: and likewise also the wife unto the husband. The wife hath not power of her own body, but the husband: and likewise also the husband hath not power of his own body, but the wife. Defraud ye not one the other, except it be with consent for a time, that ye may give yourselves to fasting and prayer; and come together again, that Satan tempt you not for your incontinency.

1 Corinthians 7:3-5

Nevertheless neither is the man without the woman, neither the woman without the man, in the Lord.

1 Corinthians 11:11

Marriage is honourable in all, and the bed undefiled: but whoremongers and adulterers God will judge.

Hebrews 13:4

Yet ye say, Wherefore? Because the LORD hath been witness between thee and the wife of thy youth, against whom thou hast dealt treacherously: yet is she thy companion, and the wife of thy covenant. Therefore take heed to your spirit, and let none deal treacherously against the wife of his youth.

Malachi 2:14-15

Let thy fountain be blessed: and rejoice with the wife of thy youth.

Proverbs 5:18